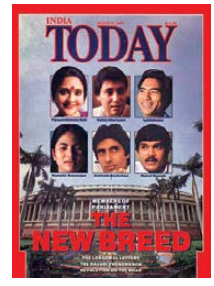
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

At one end, take a Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani. He is 48, US-returned, and a physician-turned-edupreneur-turned-politician with Rs 5,705 crore in declared assets. The wealthiest contestant in the 2024 election, he now enters the sanctum of Indian democracy as a member of Parliament from Andhra Pradesh's chilli capital Guntur. Manoj Tigga and Bhaskar Bhagare, 52 and 53, respectively, are not much older. They have a link with education too, and are fellow debutant MPs. But there the resemblance ends. Tigga was a primary school teacher in Alipurduar, in the foothills of north Bengal, where his parents were tea plantation labourers from the Oraon tribe. And Bhagare 'Guruji', who taught History and Marathi to schoolkids in Nashik district for 33 years, had to crowdfund his fight for the Dindori seat. The contingent of first-time MPs in 2024 are a bundle of such fascinating contrasts. For instance, there are names from royal dynastic lineages extending centuries. But there's also Sanjna Jatav, a young Dalit from a Bharatpur village, whose Rajasthani-style dance after victory became a celebration of democracy itself. Or take the contrast in experience. Mitali Bag, a former anganwadi worker and also the poorest debutant MP, had not seen anything higher than a zilla parishad in her West Bengal constituency, Arambag. But among the debutants are also eight former chief ministers. Along with the ilk of Shivraj Singh Chouhan, who returns for a sixth term after his last bout in 2005, there are first-timers like Basavaraj Bommai, Charanjit Singh Channi and Manohar Lal Khattar.



August 31, 1985

The inaugural session of the 18th Lok Sabha from June 24 to July 2, though largely ceremonial in function, contained enough drama to pique everyone's curiosity. Many familiar faces were among the dramatis personae. But there is also a large batch of 280 debutant MPs in the new Lok Sabha, if you count those who have been parliamentarians before but in the Upper House. This may be 34 short of the figure of 314 notched up by the 2014 Lok Sabha, a high tide mark not matched since 1984. But it's over a dozen more than the 267 first-timers of 2019. More to the point, they constitute a *majority* of the House—over 50 per cent of the total.

A fresher's harvest so wide-ranging, from so many diverse social/cultural/political backgrounds, that not even political experts can claim to know them all. So before the Budget session, we introduce you to the full cast of newcomers in this special issue. Think of it as a Who's Who among the New, a ready reckoner on the Class of 2024. It's much more than just a directory. What you will find unfolding across these pages is a mini-epic made up of short political biographies. Each first-time MP's appearance in the new Parliament is related to something novel in the political field. It is a mark of change. Think of it therefore as a guidebook to India's democracy, a collector's edition that will far outlive its immediate purpose. What you get, in totality, is a grand canvas that tells you how politics in India is evolving.

A statistical breakdown yields fascinating insights into how change is occurring. There are 52 young MPs in all—if you take 40 as the upper-age limit—and their ratio of distribution is broadly proportionate to individual party strengths. But 38 of them are debutants. And here, you find the Telugu Desam Party and the Samajwadi Party scoring the highest, with 75 per cent and 73 per cent of their MPs being first-timers, respectively—so the spectacular comebacks the two parties registered in their respective states of Andhra Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh has been on the back of a near-total renovation of personnel. The Congress, too, has its contingent of freshers, constituting 61 per cent of its overall strength; the ruling BJP comes in only at 45 per cent. At the same time, Karnataka, a state that held firm for the BJP, tops the states with 71 per cent. So, the presence of fresh blood has been decisive to overall outcomes. Those in the age band of 51-60 account for the highest number of debutant MPs: 89. Not spring chicken, but relatively young in politics, seeing as how even Rahul Gandhi, at 54, has not quite shed his 'youth icon' image. A healthy 44 of the 74 women MPs are first-timers too.

Our data package gives you the overall patterns too: how educated our MPs are, how rich or poor, how many have criminal cases, who has how many children. None of this is trivial, since we are talking about policymakers. But there's nothing like putting faces on facts to bring them alive. It's one thing to say a reassuring 201 of the 280 first-timers are graduates and above, quite another to know that Rabindra Narayan Behera, BJP MP from Jajpur, Odisha, is a professor of computer science engineering, with a PhD in Artificial Intelligence. Or that Angomcha Bimol Akoijam, the Congress MP from Inner Manipur, is a professor at Jawaharlal Nehru University who majors in social/political psychology, with minor credits in filmmaking, but who could also have been a rock star. The House is not devoid of film stars, of course. The fresh releases include contemporaries like Kangna Ranaut, Sayani Ghosh and June Maliah as well as veterans like Suresh Gopi and Arun Govil. We have organised the 280 newbies into a total of 25 categories. By age profile: from Gen-Zers like Sanjana Jatav (26) or Priya Saroj (25) to the Septuagenarians like Jitan Ram Manjhi (79). There are those who have come from the Rajya Sabha, like Union minister Piyush Goyal. And the novices: those who have never even been in a state legislative council before. There's the Dalit icon Chandrashekhar, who won against four big parties. Like him, a whole series of Giant-Slayers have arrived against the punter's odds. Find here Tycoons, Doctors and Bureaucrats rubbing shoulders with Godmen and Preachers, comrades from the far left—and yes, also the Radicals like Amritpal Singh and Engineer Rashid. Each one is a window to reality.

The House of the People reflects the popular will. We honour that with this special issue. Stitching together the stories of 280 MPs spread across the country, getting them photographed, all of this required a gargantuan effort. Sorting them into categories too was a challenge, because many of them fit several boxes at once. We went with the most standout traits. That may or may not be the reason why you hear from them in the future. But it's most probable that you will be hearing from them.



(Aroon Purie)